Sangam Literature

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Introduction to Sangam Literature

Sangam literature is the earliest body of classical Tamil poetry and one of the oldest literary traditions in India. It was composed roughly between 300 BCE and 300 CE, although scholars debate the exact dates and some place it between the 1st and 3rd centuries CE. The word "Sangam" means an assembly or academy, and according to Tamil tradition, three great Sangams, or assemblies of poets and scholars, were held under the patronage of the Pandya kings in ancient Madurai and in earlier cities now believed lost to the sea, which were called the First, Middle and Last (Mudhal, Idai and Kadai) Sangams. Only the works of the third Sangam have survived. Sangam literature gives a vivid picture of the life, trade, love, war, kingship, religion and society of ancient Tamil Nadu.

What Is Sangam Literature?

Sangam literature is a collection of about 2,381 poems composed by around 473 poets, including more than 30 women poets, such as Avvaiyar, Kakkaipadiniyar Nachchellaiyar, Ponmudiyar and Velliveethiyar. The poets came from all walks of life, including kings, merchants, farmers, potters, blacksmiths and priests. The poems were written in Old Tamil and are noted for their realistic, secular tone and detailed descriptions of nature. The main works are grouped into two large collections: the Ettuthokai (Eight Anthologies) and the Pattuppattu (Ten Idylls). The collection, together with the grammar Tolkappiyam, forms the foundation of Tamil literature.

Name Two Sangam Works

Two important Sangam works are Purananuru and Akananuru. Purananuru, "four hundred poems of the outer life", is an anthology of 400 poems on war, kings, generosity and the life of heroes. Akananuru, "four hundred poems of the inner life", is a collection of 400 love poems. Other works in the Eight Anthologies are Natrinai, Kuruntokai, Aingurunuru, Padirruppattu, Paripadal and Kalittokai. The Ten Idylls include Thirumurugarruppadai, Porunararruppadai, Sirupanarruppadai, Perumpanarruppadai, Mullaippattu, Maduraikkanci, Nedunalvadai, Kurinjippattu, Pattinappalai and Malaipadukadam. The Tolkappiyam, the oldest surviving Tamil grammar, written by Tolkappiyar, is also from the early period. The epics Silappatikaram by Ilango Adigal and Manimekalai by Sittalai Sattanar belong to the post-Sangam period, about the 5th to 6th century CE, and the Thirukkural is also considered post-Sangam.

What Are Akam and Puram Poems?

Sangam poetry is divided into two broad themes: akam and puram. Akam means "inner" and refers to poems about the inner life of human beings, especially love, in its aspects of union, waiting, quarrels, separation and pining. Akam poems do not name real people; the hero and heroine are anonymous, called by general terms, so that the emotions are universal. Akam poems follow a system of five landscapes, called thinai, each tied to a mood of love. Kurinji (the mountains) stands for the union of lovers; Mullai (the forest and pastures) for patient waiting; Marutham (the farmland) for quarrels and sulking; Neithal (the seashore) for pining and anxious longing; and Palai (the arid land) for separation. Each landscape has its own flowers, animals, gods, birds, time of the day and season, so the poems use nature as a way of expressing emotion.

Puram means "outer" and refers to poems about the outer, public life: war, valour, kingship, generosity, ethics, death and the glory of heroes. Puram poems name the real kings and chieftains, such as Karikala Chola, Pari, Athiyaman and Ay, and their battles. They sing of the generosity of Pari, who gave his chariot to a jasmine creeper, and they also include elegies. Puram also has its own thinais, for example Vetchi (cattle raiding), Vanji (invasion), Ulinai (siege), Tumbai (battle) and Vakai (victory). A famous line of Purananuru by Kaniyan Pungundranar, "Yaadhum oore yaavarum kelir", meaning "every town is our own, everyone is our kin", expresses a universal vision, and was quoted at the United Nations.

Historical Value

Sangam poems tell us about the ancient Tamil kingdoms of the Cheras, Cholas and Pandyas, called the Muventhar, and about their ports such as Poompuhar (Kaveripattinam), Muziris and Korkai. The Pattinappalai describes the busy trade at Poompuhar. Sangam texts mention trade with the Romans, who were called Yavanas, with gold coming into the country in exchange for pepper, pearls, ivory and fine cotton, and Roman coins and amphorae found at sites such as Arikamedu near Puducherry, Alagankulam and Keeladi confirm this. Excavations at Keeladi near Madurai have shown an urban Tamil civilisation of about the 6th century BCE, with evidence of literacy, which adds to the credibility of the Sangam age. The literature also describes festivals, dress, food, music, dance, farming and fishing.

Rediscovery and Recognition

For many centuries, the palm-leaf manuscripts of Sangam poems were forgotten. The scholar U. V. Swaminatha Iyer (1855 to 1942), often called "Tamil Thatha", travelled to villages and monasteries collecting palm-leaf manuscripts, and he published Sangam works starting with Pattuppattu in 1889 and Purananuru in 1894, bringing them back to public awareness. Others, such as C. W. Damodaram Pillai, also helped. In 2004, the Government of India declared Tamil a classical language, the first language to be given this status, in recognition of its ancient, independent tradition. The Central Institute of Classical Tamil in Chennai promotes research. Sangam poetry has been translated into English by scholars such as A. K. Ramanujan, whose "The Interior Landscape" brought it to a global readership, and George L. Hart.

Sangam Literature Today

Sangam themes have influenced Tamil poetry, film songs and modern literature, and many Tamil names come from it. Madurai, which the tradition links to the Sangams, has the Tamil Sangam building and the Tamil Nadu government's Madurai Meenakshi temple area, along with the Thirumalai Nayakkar Mahal. Schools and universities teach Sangam poems.

Challenges and Future

Some manuscripts are lost, and the dating of the poems is still debated. Digital archives, new excavations at Keeladi and translations are helping to preserve the legacy for future generations.

Quick Facts

- Sangam literature was composed roughly between 300 BCE and 300 CE and has about 2,381 poems by around 473 poets.
- Akam poems are about love; puram poems are about war, kings, generosity and public life.
- Two Sangam works are Purananuru and Akananuru.
- The five akam landscapes are Kurinji, Mullai, Marutham, Neithal and Palai.
- Tamil was declared a classical language in 2004.